

Sweetgreen: Final Report

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Problem/Opportunity

Founded in 2007, Sweetgreen is known as a fast-casual chain built around salads, grain bowls, and warm protein plates. The current marketing strategy is holding the core message of “connecting people to real food.”¹ Their main target audience is urban professionals and health-conscious consumers, and they offer a premium, sustainability-focused brand. Their menu ranges from \$14 to \$20 per bowl, and they have over 250 U.S. locations. Their revenue is mainly digital, with 60% of orders via the app (see Exhibit 1). As of 2026, Sweetgreen is shifting away from “lower funnel conversion-focused” marketing toward upper-funnel brand awareness and resetting its media mix to focus on positioning Sweetgreen “in the hearts and minds of consumers.”² They have also been altering their loyalty program, disrupting their sales.

The fast-casual food market is expanding, with an expected increase of 84.5 billion USD, at a CAGR of 13.7% from 2024 to 2029 (see Exhibit 2).³ Key competitors to Sweetgreen that offer the fast-casual experience many customers enjoy include CAVA, Chipotle Mexican Grill, and Chop’t. CAVA offers Mediterranean bowls and has over 350 locations, and it is currently in growth mode, while Sweetgreen is shrinking. Chipotle is even larger, with over 3,400 locations, and a dominant digital platform that exceeds Sweetgreen. Then there is Chop’t, a smaller regional salad chain that offers a product very similar to Sweetgreen's while also offering certain items at lower price points, starting at \$12 per bowl. Sweetgreen has been seeing a decline across quarters, with same-store sales falling every quarter in 2025. Q1 it declined 3.1%, Q2 declined 7.6%, Q3 declined 9.5%, Q4 declined more at 11.5%.⁴ Each quarter's traffic decline worsened,

¹ Sweetgreen. Our Mission. Sweetgreen, <https://www.sweetgreen.com/mission>

² Jennings, Lisa. “Sweetgreen Wants to Be a Lifestyle Brand Again.” Restaurant Business Online, 12 Mar. 2026, <https://www.restaurantbusinessonline.com/marketing/sweetgreen-wants-be-lifestyle-brand-again>

³ Technavio. Fast Casual Restaurants Market in US 2025–2029. Technavio, 2025, <https://www.technavio.com/report/fast-casual-restaurants-market-industry-in-us-analysis>

⁴ Sweetgreen, Inc. Form 10-K. U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission, 2024, <https://d18rn0p25nwr6d.cloudfront.net/CIK-0001639438/34d0b160-4232-40d4-b4e9-a306f12279aa.pdf>

signaling more than simply a temporary dip. On the other hand, CAVA reported positive same-store sales in Q3 2025.⁵ They saw a 0.9% increase in same-store sales in Q3 2025 and a 4% increase in full-year same-store sales, with 1.6% traffic growth, outperforming Sweetgreen in the same macro environment.

With this information, we see that Sweetgreen is facing sustained erosion in customer traffic, driven mainly by macroeconomic pressures, a disruptive loyalty program transition, and rising menu prices, while direct competitors like CAVA maintain positive same-store sales. The opportunity lies in identifying which marketing and retention strategies can reverse the decline in visit frequency without compromising the brand's premium identity. Consequently, this study evaluates the specific drivers of decline to determine the most viable path toward sustainable growth.

Research Approach & Design

Our research employed a two-phase, mixed-methods design. Phase I used qualitative research to develop hypotheses and explore consumer sentiment, and Phase II used quantitative survey research to test those hypotheses at scale and generate statistically actionable findings.

Research Question

After reviewing the various struggles Sweetgreen seemed to be facing in our secondary research, we wanted to understand: **What is driving Sweetgreen's drop in customer traffic, and which marketing changes would be most effective at increasing visits?**

Phase I - Qualitative Research

⁵ CAVA Group, Inc. Form 10-K. U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission, 2024, <https://d18rn0p25nwr6d.cloudfront.net/CIK-0001639438/34d0b160-4232-40d4-b4e9-a306f12279aa.pdf>

The first method we used was a focus group to better understand people's perceptions and opinions of the brand. Our focus group consisted of 7 college-aged participants (5 women, 2 men, ages approximately 18–22) in a 60-minute session to discuss their thoughts on the brand, competitors, habits, likes and dislikes, etc. Based on this group we learned the following: price was the largest factor on their decision not to eat at Sweetgreen, they didn't feel that full after eating a meal from there, they perceived the brand as being healthy and having a "clean" reputation, they would like having more meal options than just bowls, and that they would appreciate a strong loyalty program that contained coupons and deal offerings for regular customers.

Phase II - Quantitative Research

Using the information we obtained from the focus group, we sent out a survey to obtain more specific results from a larger, more representative group. This survey consisted of 27 (non-demographic-based) questions and gathered 119 respondents. This questionnaire's purpose was to go more in-depth, starting with questions about their eating habits (priorities, in- and out-of-home, fast casual) to better understand the industry and the larger market that Sweetgreen fits into. After this, we moved on to questions about Sweetgreen's specific habits, such as familiarity, ordering methods, perceptions, order frequency, etc. After gaining initial insight into this specific company, we posed perception questions to two of Sweetgreen's leading competitors: Cava and Chopt. This was to provide a direct comparison to understand what Sweetgreen was up against in the industry and whether its positioning had a direct impact on customer traffic. From there, it moved on to specific, in-depth questions about what may have influenced this decline. Respondents were asked about how their visit frequency has changed, what would make them more inclined to visit, what would make Sweetgreen "worth it"

compared to competitors, etc. The core purpose of this survey was to identify all potential problems with the business and determine their root causes. These results can be found in the next section.

Data Analysis & Results

Subsection I - Descriptive Statistics

This section outlines key patterns in how consumers perceive Sweetgreen, how they behave, and what influences their decisions.

A comparison of brand perceptions among Sweetgreen, Cava, and Chopt reveals clear differences (see Exhibit 3). Sweetgreen is rated highest for healthiness and performs well on quality, supporting its positioning as a health-focused brand. However, it scores lowest on affordability, suggesting that many consumers see it as more expensive than competitors. Cava stands out for overall favorability and convenience, while Chop't generally scores lower across most attributes. Overall, this suggests that while Sweetgreen is seen as high-quality and healthy, its higher perceived price may limit its appeal relative to competitors.

These patterns are consistent with focus group insights, in which participants described Sweetgreen as fresh and high-quality, but also repeatedly emphasized that it feels expensive relative to what you get.

Looking at behavior, visit frequency has been relatively stable over the past year (see Exhibit 4). Most respondents said their visits to Sweetgreen have stayed the same, and a large portion reported never visiting at all. Only a small group reported an increase in visits. This suggests limited growth in visit frequency among this sample and indicates an opportunity to

more actively drive traffic. Focus group participants similarly described Sweetgreen as more of an occasional treat rather than a regular habit.

When asked what would need to change to increase their likelihood of visiting, price clearly stood out as the most important factor (Exhibit 5). A majority of respondents said they would be more likely to visit if meals were cheaper, with over half saying they would be ‘much more likely.’ Increasing portion sizes had some impact, but not to the same extent, while changes such as improving the loyalty program or adding more menu variety had relatively little effect. Overall, this indicates that pricing is the strongest stated driver of visit intent. These findings align closely with focus group feedback, where nearly all participants identified lower prices and better value as the most important changes Sweetgreen could make

This finding is further reinforced by the mean importance scores we found in our survey, which rank the factors that make Sweetgreen feel more “worth it” (see Exhibit 6; Appendix C8 and C9). We see that faster pick-up is the least important, while lower prices are the most important. This pattern suggests that perceived economic value plays a larger role than convenience or experiential enhancements in shaping customer perceptions of value.

Subsection II - Drivers of Visit Frequency

To better understand what actually drives customer behavior, the analysis focuses on how key perceptions influence visit frequency.

Perceived value is one of the strongest drivers of repeat visits (Appendix C1). Customers who believe Sweetgreen is worth the price tend to visit more frequently, suggesting that price alone is not the determining factor; rather, it is whether customers feel they are receiving sufficient value. Portion size plays an equally critical role and shows an even stronger relationship with visit frequency (Appendix C2). In fact, this relationship appears stronger than

that of price perception alone. Customers who perceive portions as fair relative to price are significantly more likely to return. These results reinforce focus group findings, in which participants frequently noted that portion sizes did not justify the cost and often left them unsatisfied, which makes consumers less likely to view Sweetgreen as their go-to meal option.

Broader brand perceptions further reinforce this pattern. Perceived quality is the strongest predictor of visit frequency, followed by healthiness (Appendix C3). Customers who see Sweetgreen as high-quality and healthy are more likely to visit more often. On the other hand, simply perceiving the brand as expensive does not significantly affect visit frequency. This suggests that while price is a concern, it only matters when it affects perceived value. Focus group participants expressed a similar idea, noting that they would be willing to pay more if the portions or overall experience felt worth it.

Subsection III - Competition

Competition also shapes customer behavior, but not all competitors influence the brand equally. Chopt emerges as the most behaviorally relevant competitor. There is a significant relationship between visits to Chopt and visits to Sweetgreen (Appendix C4), indicating that the two brands share a highly overlapping customer base. Customers who visit Chopt more often also tend to visit Sweetgreen more often, indicating overlapping usage rather than a substitution effect. In contrast, brands like Chipotle and Cava do not show the same relationship, suggesting that they do not have a strong connection to Sweetgreen visit behavior.

Price comparisons further reinforce this. Customers who perceive Sweetgreen as more expensive than Chopt tend to visit less frequently, while comparisons with other brands are not significant (Appendix C5). This indicates that price sensitivity is most pronounced in direct,

side-by-side comparisons with similar offerings, rather than across the entire fast-casual restaurant category.

While Chipotle is the most commonly visited alternative overall (Appendix C6), Chopt appears to function as the closer substitute influencing Sweetgreen's visit frequency. This suggests that Chipotle operates in a different competitive space. These findings align with focus group insights, in which participants frequently mentioned choosing Chopt or Cava over Sweetgreen for better value and larger portions. This reinforces that the primary competitive threat is not the largest brand in the category, but the one that delivers a similar product at a better perceived value. In particular, Chopt was often described as offering a similar product at a lower price, reinforcing its role as a direct competitor.

Subsection IV - Marketing Insights

Current marketing efforts are not effectively influencing customer behavior. Seeing Sweetgreen advertisements does not meaningfully change customers' likelihood of visiting, suggesting that current advertising strategies may not be effectively influencing behavior (see Exhibit 7; Appendix C7). This is consistent with focus group findings, where most participants reported low awareness of Sweetgreen's marketing and noted that advertising rarely influences their decision to visit. Instead, decisions are driven by price, convenience, and perceived value.

Differences across groups are also minimal. College and non-college respondents generally prioritize the same factors, especially lower prices and discounts, suggesting that these value drivers are consistent across segments. This aligns with focus group discussions, where participants expressed similar priorities, particularly around affordability and portion size.

The issue is not a lack of awareness, but misalignment. Sweetgreen's marketing emphasizes lifestyle and brand imagery, while customer decisions are driven by perceived value,

portion size, and quality. As a result, current messaging does not address the factors that determine whether customers choose to visit. For Sweetgreen, this creates a clear strategic gap.

Recommendations

Introduce a Value Combo Tier

The most urgent finding in our data is that 91% of respondents said a cheaper meal would make them much more or somewhat more likely to visit, the single strongest behavioral lever in the entire dataset. Yet Sweetgreen currently offers no entry-level pricing option: every order starts at \$14 and customization only drives costs higher. This leaves a significant share of potential customers, particularly students and budget-conscious urban workers, priced out of regular visits entirely. We recommend that Sweetgreen introduce a clearly branded value combo tier: a simplified, fixed-price meal at a \$10–\$12 price point consisting of a base bowl or grain cup paired with one protein and one topping. This is not a discount; rather, it is a distinct menu tier that lowers the barrier to trial and repeat visits without undermining the premium positioning of the full menu. Think of it as a Sweetgreen "everyday" option alongside the full build-your-own experience.

The data directly support this framing. Customers ranked lower prices as the most important driver of perceived value, and more discounts as the second most important. A combo tier achieves both: it delivers a structurally lower price while communicating generosity. From a competitive standpoint, Chopt, confirmed as Sweetgreen's closest substitute, starts at \$12/bowl, and CAVA offers pita and sides that make meals feel more complete at a similar spend. A Sweetgreen combo tier closes that competitive gap without requiring across-the-board price cuts. It also gives the loyalty program a natural mechanic: earning a free combo upgrade after a set

number of visits is a low-cost, high-perceived-value reward that simultaneously addresses customers' second-ranked priority.

Increase Portion Consistency and Size:

Sweetgreen's portion sizes and the consistency with which they are executed play a central role in shaping whether customers feel the brand is "worth it." Across the data, perceptions of portion fairness emerged as one of the strongest drivers of repeat visits, signaling that customers are not simply reacting to price alone but to the relationship between what they pay and how satisfied they feel afterward. Customers sense a lack of value when portions vary from visit to visit, or when bowls appear sparse relative to the price. This erodes trust and makes Sweetgreen feel less reliable as an everyday meal option, particularly for students and urban professionals who are highly sensitive to whether a meal will actually keep them full. With this analysis in mind, our team recommends that Sweetgreen invest in improving both portion size and portion consistency across locations. Doing so would directly strengthen the value perception that most heavily influences customer behavior, reinforce Sweetgreen's high-quality, high-integrity focus, and make the brand feel worth returning to.

App / Loyalty Program

A clear conclusion from the existing app and loyalty program experience, as well as our data analysis, is that Sweetgreen's digital ecosystem is not yet being used to reinforce the value dimension that most strongly shapes customer behavior. The app and loyalty program primarily function as convenience tools, streamlining ordering, saving favorites, and offering occasional promotions, but they do little to address the portion-versus-price tension that determines whether customers feel a Sweetgreen meal is "worth it." Customers are looking for rewards and digital touchpoints that enhance the meal itself, not just the transaction. With this in mind, our team

recommends evolving the loyalty program to offer benefits that directly enhance perceived value, such as early access to the Combo Tier, a secret menu, and order recommendations tailored to one's health goals. These are rewards customers can see and taste, aligning with Sweetgreen's premium identity while generating exclusivity and excitement. Additionally, the app should play a more active role in showcasing improved portion sizes, rewarding successful referrals, and personalizing nudges that make Sweetgreen feel like a reliable, satisfying everyday choice. By shifting the digital experience from transactional to value-forward, Sweetgreen can rebuild trust, strengthen loyalty, and create a more compelling reason for customers to return.

Social Media / Marketing:

The clearest marketing implication from our analysis is that Sweetgreen's current advertising strategy is failing to influence customer behavior in any meaningful way. The likelihood of visiting was identical for customers who had seen recent ads and those who had not, confirming that exposure to Sweetgreen's marketing does not translate into increased intent to visit. This signals a fundamental misalignment between Sweetgreen's current messaging, which is focused on lifestyle imagery, and the factors that actually drive customer behavior: value, portion size, and quality. Therefore, our team recommends a pivot toward value-forward, fullness-forward, and quality-forward messaging that directly addresses the portion-price tension identified in the data. This shift should be anchored by the clearly branded \$10–\$12 Combo Tier, the hero product across all marketing channels. The Combo Tier allows Sweetgreen to communicate product value while offering a structurally lower price point that does not dilute the premium positioning of the broader menu. It also aligns with the growing cultural emphasis on protein as a marker of both health and satiety; positioning the Combo Tier as a high-protein, high-value meal taps directly into one of the strongest trends in the food and wellness space.

Given that Chopt was identified as the closest overlapping competitor in our data, our team recommends that Sweetgreen concentrate its paid media efforts in areas where Chopt is present. Geo-targeted ads near Chopt locations, paired with messaging that highlights Sweetgreen's superior protein content, ingredient quality, and value, would allow Sweetgreen to compete more effectively for a shared customer base. This approach targets locations where cross-shopping is most likely, positioning Sweetgreen more strongly when customers are looking for a fast-casual salad option.

At the same time, Sweetgreen should expand its influencer and ambassador ecosystem to rebuild credibility around what makes its offerings "worth it". Nutrition-forward creators can authentically demonstrate portion size and protein content in ways that traditional ads have failed to do. College ambassadors, in particular, are well-positioned to reach the student segment that is both highly price-sensitive and highly responsive to protein-forward messaging. Together, these tactics create a cohesive marketing system that directly addresses the behavioral drivers behind Sweetgreen customers' decisions.

At the same time, it is important to note that Sweetgreen has recently begun incorporating value-focused messaging into its advertising. Recent campaigns emphasize lower price points (e.g., \$10 meals) and highlight protein content as a signal of both health and satiety (see Exhibit 8). This shift directly aligns with our findings that perceived value, driven by price and portion satisfaction, is the primary driver of customer behavior. Continuing and expanding these messages through influencers and ambassadors can further reinforce and amplify this positioning in a more credible and relatable way, particularly among price-sensitive segments.

Conclusion

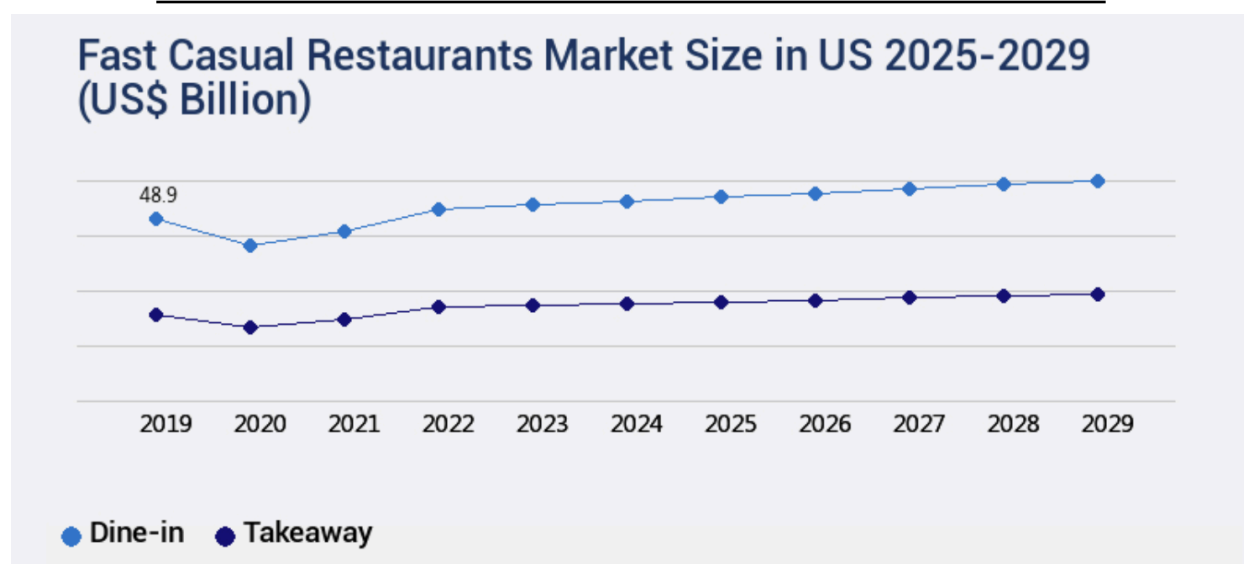
Across our research and analysis, we found a consistent pattern that customers are not simply reacting to price, but to whether the portion and overall experience justify that price. For Sweetgreen, this means the solution is not just about lowering costs but about increasing the perceived customer value relative to its prices. By aligning pricing, portion sizes, and messaging around perceived value, Sweetgreen can more effectively drive repeat visits and sustain customer engagement.

Exhibits

Exhibit 1: Sweetgreen’s Current Marketing Strategy

Marketing Mix Element	Description	Key Details
Product	Customizable salads, grain bowls, and warm bowls made with seasonal, locally sourced ingredients.	Core menu plus rotating seasonal items (e.g., Harvest Bowl). Limited warm/protein options vs. competitors.
Price	Premium fast-casual pricing averaging \$14–\$18 per entrée.	Perceived as expensive relative to competitors; limited discounting strategy.
Place	250+ U.S. locations concentrated in urban markets and major metros (NYC, Boston, LA, DC).	Digital-first: majority of orders placed via app or third-party delivery (DoorDash, UberEats).
Promotion	Social media–led marketing (Instagram, TikTok), influencer partnerships, and PR-driven brand campaigns.	Sweetpass loyalty program; brand collaborations (e.g., Madhappy). Minimal traditional/TV advertising.
People & Experience	Emphasis on brand identity: clean aesthetics, sustainability messaging, transparent ingredient sourcing.	In-store environment designed around minimalist, 'healthy lifestyle' brand positioning.

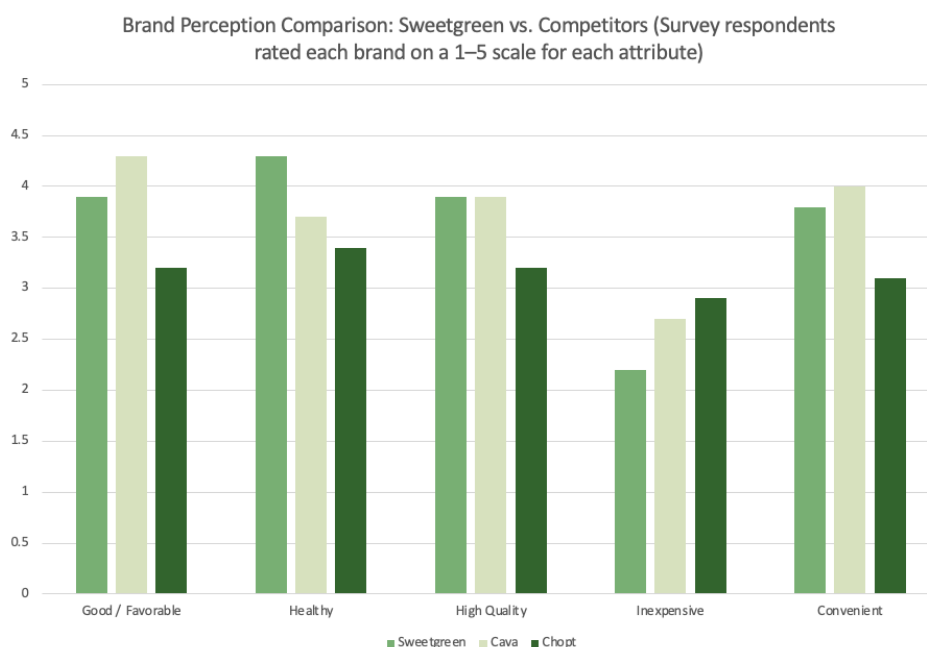
Exhibit 2: Fast Casual Restaurants Market Size in the U.S. 2025-2029



⁶Source: “US Fast Casual Restaurants Market Size 2025–2029.” *Technavio*, <https://www.technavio.com/report/fast-casual-restaurants-market-industry-in-us-analysis>

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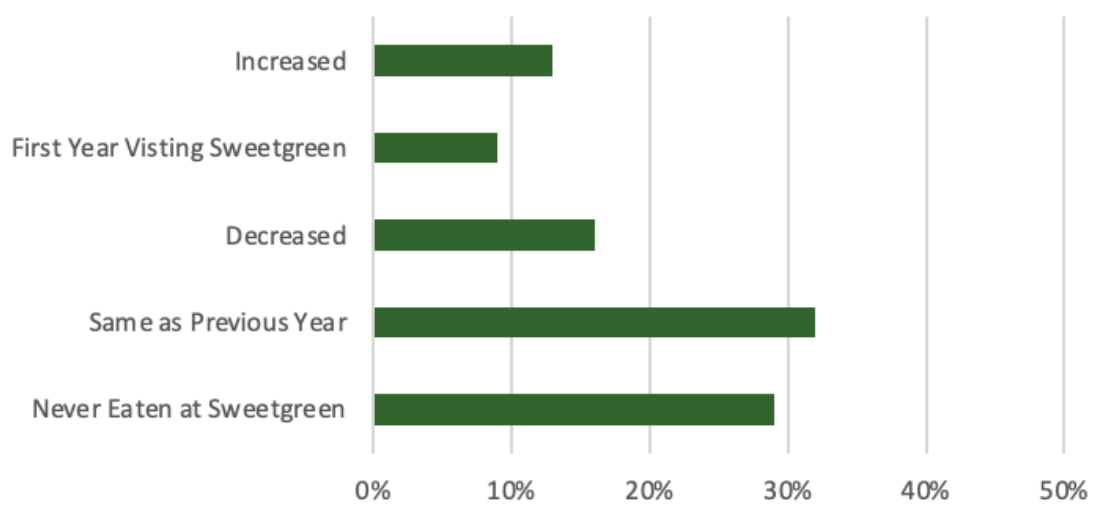
Exhibit 3: Brand Perception Comparison - Sweetgreen vs. Competitors



⁷ Source: MKTG 2153 Primary Survey Data, Spring 2026

Exhibit 4: Sweetgreen Visit Frequency Change Over the Past Year

Sweetgreen Visit Frequency Change Over the Past Year (% of survey respondents)



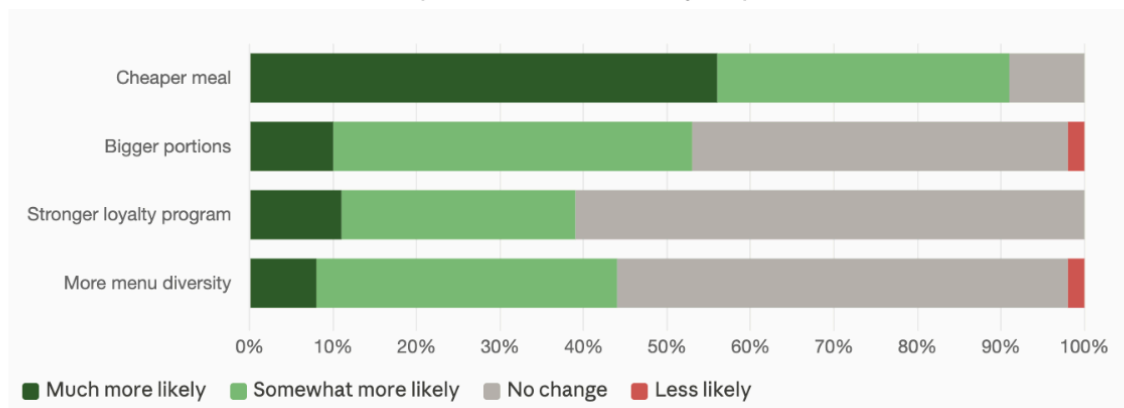
⁸ Source: MKTG 2153 Primary Survey Data, Spring 2026

⁷ Source: MKTG 2153 Primary Survey Data, Spring 2026

⁸ Source: MKTG 2153 Primary Survey Data, Spring 2026

Exhibit 5: If Sweetgreen Made the Following Changes, How Would Your Likelihood of Visiting Change?

*If Sweetgreen made the following changes, how would your likelihood of visiting change?
% of respondents — stacked by response*



⁹ Source: MKTG 2153 Primary Survey Data, Spring 2026

Exhibit 6: Mean Score on Different Factors (Scale 1-5)

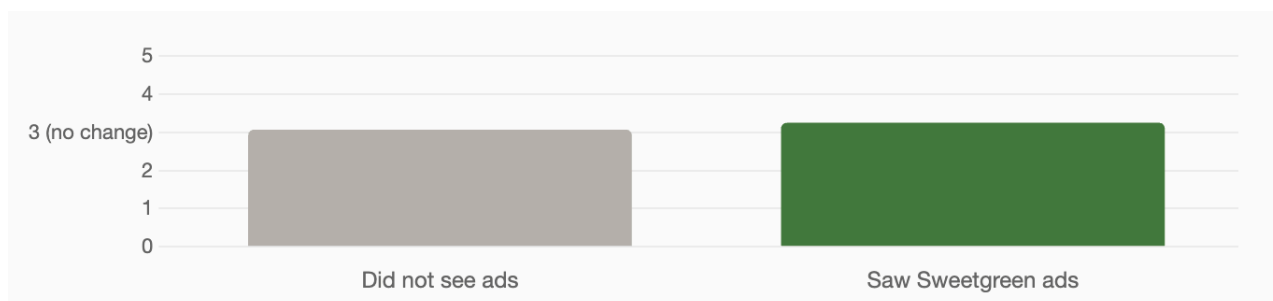
Rank	Factor	Mean Score (higher = more important)
1	Lower Prices	M = 3.38 (most important)
2	More Discounts	M = 3.04
3	Bigger Portions	M = 2.75
4	More Locations	M = 2.26
5	More Menu Variety	M = 2.20
6	Better Loyalty Program	M = 2.18
7	Faster Pickup	M = 2.01 (least important)

¹⁰ Source: MKTG 2153 Primary Survey Data, Spring 2026

⁹ Source: MKTG 2153 Primary Survey Data, Spring 2026

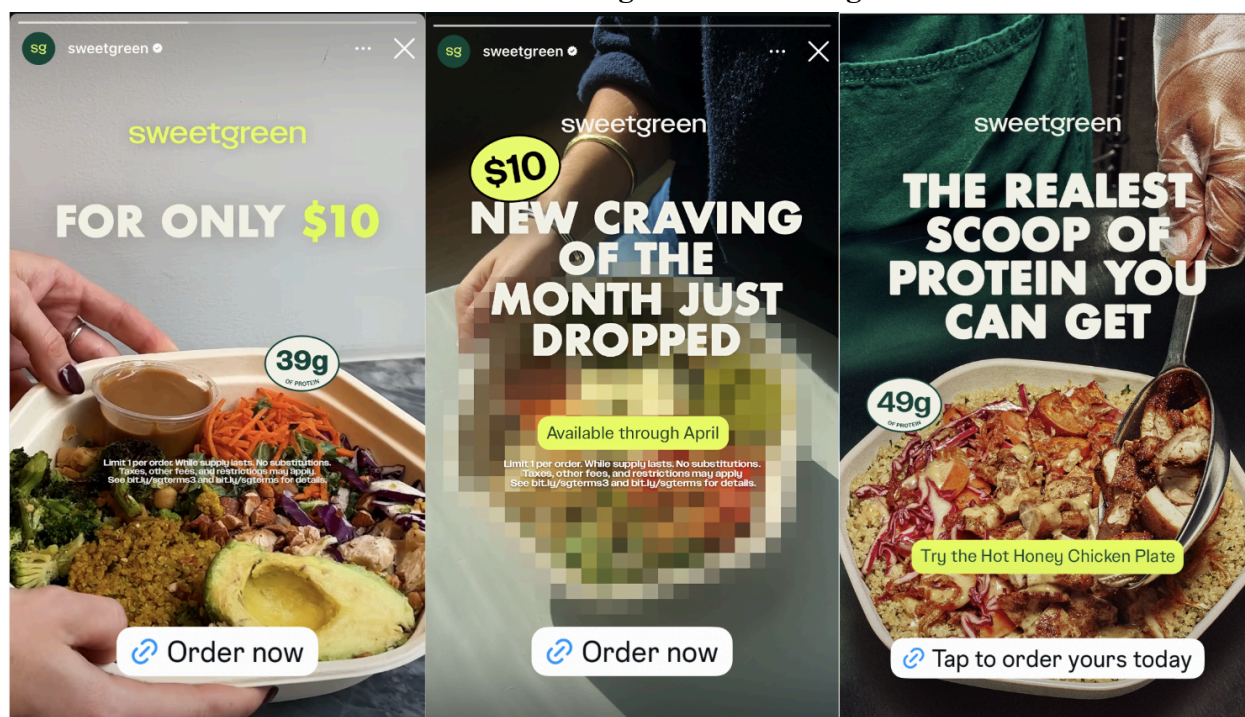
¹⁰ Source: MKTG 2153 Primary Survey Data, Spring 2026

Exhibit 7: Did seeing Sweetgreen ads change your likelihood of visiting? (Mean likelihood of visiting (1 = much less likely, 3 = no change, 5 = much more likely))



¹¹ Source: MKTG 2153 Primary Survey Data, Spring 2026

Exhibit 8: Sweetgreen Advertising



¹² Source: Sweetgreen (@sweetgreen). Instagram, <https://www.instagram.com/sweetgreen/>

¹¹ Source: MKTG 2153 Primary Survey Data, Spring 2026

¹² Sweetgreen (@sweetgreen). Instagram, <https://www.instagram.com/sweetgreen/>.

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Appendix A: Focus Group Discussion Guide & Summary Notes

Focus Group (N=7): 5 women, 2 men; aged approximately 18–22.

Brand: Sweetgreen

Session Length: 60 minutes

Objective: Understand consumer perceptions, behaviors, and barriers related to Sweetgreen's declining customer traffic, and identify marketing and experience changes that could most effectively increase visits.

Introduction (5 minutes)

- Thank participants for joining
- Moderator disclosure: not employed by Sweetgreen or its competitors
- Explain:
 - 60-minute discussion
 - Audio/video recording and observation
 - No right or wrong answers — honest opinions encouraged
- Research objective: To understand how people think about Sweetgreen today, how it fits into their lives, and what would make them visit more often.
- Participant introductions:
 - Name and where they live
 - When you don't want to cook or go to the dining hall, where do you think about going or ordering?
 - How do you decide? (e.g., price, time, health, accessibility, who you are with)
 - What types of food do you like to eat?

Eating-Out & Fast-Casual Context (10 minutes)

Goal: Establish category behavior and decision criteria.

- Walk me through the last few times you ate out or ordered food.
- What types of restaurants do you choose most often?
- Describe a good restaurant experience you had.
- Describe a bad restaurant experience you had.
- What factors matter most when choosing where to eat? (e.g., price, health, convenience, taste, portion size, reliability)
- What trade-offs do you typically make when deciding where to eat?

Sweetgreen Awareness & Perception (10 minutes)

Goal: Understand top-of-mind brand associations.

- What comes to mind when you think of Sweetgreen? (words, images, feelings)
- How would you describe Sweetgreen to someone who has never been there?

- What role does Sweetgreen play in your life today? (regular habit, occasional treat, special-purpose meal, etc.)
- Compared to other fast-casual restaurants, how does Sweetgreen feel similar or different?
- What other fast-casual restaurants do you see yourself reaching for most often?
 - Do any of these have options that Sweetgreen does not?

Usage & Visit Behavior (5 minutes)

Goal: Identify behavior patterns and visit frequency drivers.

- When was the last time you visited Sweetgreen? What prompted that visit?
- How has your Sweetgreen visit frequency changed over the past year? (Increased, decreased, or stayed the same? Why?)
- In what situations does Sweetgreen feel like a "good choice" for you? (lunch, dinner, post-workout, social, convenience, etc.)

Barriers to Visit & Traffic Decline (10 minutes)

Goal: Uncover reasons behind declining traffic.

- What are the main reasons you don't choose Sweetgreen more often?
- How do you feel about Sweetgreen's prices relative to what you get?
- Do you feel satisfied after a Sweetgreen meal? Why or why not?
- Have recent economic factors (inflation, budgeting, student loans, etc.) changed how often you eat at Sweetgreen?
- When you skip Sweetgreen, where do you usually go instead — and why?

Marketing & Communication Perceptions (5 minutes)

Goal: Evaluate the effectiveness of current messaging.

- What kinds of Sweetgreen marketing have you noticed recently, if any? (social media, email, app notifications, in-store, word of mouth)
- What messages stand out to you most from Sweetgreen? (health, sustainability, ingredients, lifestyle, convenience)
- Do Sweetgreen's marketing messages make you want to visit more often? Why or why not?

Solutions & Opportunity Exploration (10 minutes)

Goal: Generate insight for actionable solutions.

- What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it" to you?
- How would promotions, bundles, or loyalty rewards influence your visit frequency?
- Describe your experiences with the Sweetgreen app. How do you use it, and would you like anything to change?
- Have you joined the loyalty program? Does it influence whether you go to Sweetgreen, or what you order?

- Are there menu, portion, or experience changes that would make you choose Sweetgreen more often?
- If Sweetgreen could change one thing, what should it be?

Wrap-Up (5 minutes)

- How does Sweetgreen fit into your lifestyle right now?
- Is there anything else you'd like Sweetgreen to understand about customers like you?
- Thank participants for their time.

Summary Notes from Focus Group

Theme 1: Price is the dominant barrier to visiting Sweetgreen.

- Six out of seven participants cited price as the single most important change Sweetgreen could make.
- Participants described the cost as "restaurant pricing for fast food" and felt portions did not justify the expense (e.g., "Give very little food for so much money").
- Several noted that visits are contingent on someone else paying; they would order without hesitation if cost were not a factor.
- Economic pressures (budgeting, student loans) have meaningfully reduced visit frequency.

Theme 2: Portion size compounds the perceived value problem.

- Participants frequently felt unsatisfied after a Sweetgreen meal, noting they were hungry within two hours.
- Cava was repeatedly cited as offering larger portions at a similar or lower price point ("Cava gives much bigger portions — sometimes Sweetgreen only gives a few lettuce leaves").
- The ability to order add-ons at an upcharge was seen as a frustrating design feature rather than customization.

Theme 3: Sweetgreen is a treat, not a routine — and often skipped in favor of closer competitors.

- Most participants described Sweetgreen as a rare or occasional indulgence, not a regular habit.
- Primary visit occasions include studying sessions, post-workout meals, or proximity-based impulse decisions.
- When skipping Sweetgreen, participants most often went to Cava, Chipotle, Chopt, or Panera — typically citing better value, comparable health profile, or closer proximity.
- One participant noted walking past Sweetgreen to go to Chopt or Panera when they shared a shopping plaza.

Theme 4: The in-store environment and brand feel sterile and uninviting.

- The Sweetgreen aesthetic was described as "victim of millennial grey" — clean and minimalist to the point of feeling cold and unwelcoming.

- Participants rarely felt compelled to dine inside; the physical space did not create a reason to stay.
- Suggestions included adding color, cushions, and more personality to the in-store experience.
- The brand was described as feeling geared toward a narrow, affluent demographic ("feels like a place finance bros go to feel sophisticated").

Theme 5: Marketing efforts have low visibility and limited persuasive impact.

- Most participants could not recall any recent Sweetgreen promotions or campaigns.
- Sweetgreen's visual identity (lowercase branding, clean design, green delivery bags) was recognized, but participants noted they never felt moved to visit based on advertising.
- Participants were more aware of competitor promotions than Sweetgreen's, and noted that Sweetgreen does not send re-engagement coupons the way other brands do.
- The health-forward messaging does not resonate unless the audience already prioritizes wellness: "Healthy messaging doesn't really land unless you are in a target demographic with a job."

Theme 6: The loyalty program is considered weak.

- Participants who had used the app primarily for ordering ahead, not for loyalty benefits.
- Several compared Sweetgreen's rewards unfavorably to Starbucks', noting it required too many purchases to earn a meaningful reward.
- Participants expressed interest in simpler, more frequent incentives such as a 20% off coupon, free extra protein, or a comeback coupon after a period of inactivity.

Theme 7: Chopt and Cava are the most direct competitors.

- Cava was described as a near-substitute that wins on portions and value, with pita offered on the side for far less than Sweetgreen's bread add-ons.
- Chopt was cited unprompted as a preferred alternative — cheaper and perceived as equally or more health-focused.
- Chipotle was mentioned frequently as a go-to for convenience and reliability, though participants acknowledged it occupies a different category.

Appendix B: MKTG2153 Survey Design

Start of Block: Introduction

Introduction "Hi! We are a student research team from Boston College conducting a survey for our Marketing Research course (MKTG2153). Our goal is to better understand how people make decisions about fast-casual dining. All responses are anonymous and confidential — your answers will only be used for class research. There are no right or wrong answers! This survey should take about 5-10 minutes to complete. If you have any questions, please contact Michelle An (anmh@bc.edu), Kimaya Dsilva (dsilvak@bc.edu), Ty Mendez (mendezt@bc.edu), Audrey Share (sharea@bc.edu), or Grace Turza (turzag@bc.edu). Thank you for taking the time to participate in this survey. Your responses are greatly appreciated.

End of Block: Introduction

Start of Block: Questions Part 1

Q1 When was the last time you ate out at a fast casual restaurant? (A fast casual restaurant is a restaurant offering higher-quality, made-to-order food without full table service.)

- ☐ Within the last 7 days (1)
- ☐ Within the last 2 weeks (2)
- ☐ Within the last month (3)
- ☐ Within the last 6 months (4)
- ☐ More than 6 months ago (5)

Q2 When was the last time you ordered from a fast-casual restaurant?

- ☐ Within the last 7 days (1)
- ☐ Within the last 2 weeks (2)
- ☐ Within the last month (3)
- ☐ Within the last 6 months (4)
- ☐ More than 6 months ago (5)
- ☐ Never (6)

Q3 At which meal time do you most frequently purchase food outside your home?

- ☐ Breakfast (1)

- ☐ Lunch (2)
- ☐ Dinner (3)
- ☐ Late night (4)

Q4 How much do you prioritize these aspects when eating out? Rank from most to least important.

- _____ Price (1)
- _____ Health (2)
- _____ Convenience/Location (3)
- _____ Taste (4)
- _____ Portion Size (5)
- _____ Customization (6)

Q5 How familiar are you with sweetgreen?

- ☐ Not familiar at all (1)
- ☐ Slightly familiar (2)
- ☐ Moderately familiar (3)
- ☐ Very familiar (4)
- ☐ Extremely familiar (5)

Q6 When you get Sweetgreen which is your most common method of ordering

- ☐ In Store (1)
- ☐ On the App (2)
- ☐ Third party service e.g. Uber Eats, Doordash (3)
- ☐ I have never had Sweetgreen (4)

Q7 When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?

- ☐ Within the last 7 days (1)
- ☐ Within the last 2 weeks (2)
- ☐ Within the last month (3)
- ☐ Within the last 6 months (4)
- ☐ Within the last year (5)
- ☐ Never (6)

Q8 For each pair of adjectives below, select the point between them that reflects the extent to which you believe either adjective describes Sweetgreen.

	Much more 1	Slightly more 2	Neutral 3	Slightly more 4	Much more 5	
	1 (1)	2 (2)	3 (3)	4 (4)	5 (5)	
Bad	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Good
Unhealthy	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Healthy
Low Quality	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	High Quality
Expensive	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Cheap
Inconvenient	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Convenient

Q9 For each pair of adjectives below, select the point between them that reflects the extent to which you believe either adjective describes Cava.

	Much more 1	Slightly more2	Neutral 3	Slightly more 4	Much more 5	
	1 (1)	2 (2)	3 (3)	4 (4)	5 (5)	
Bad	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Good
Unhealthy	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Healthy
Low Quality	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	High Quality
Expensive	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Cheap

Inconvenient	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Convenient
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Q32 For each pair of adjectives below, select the point between them that reflects the extent to which you believe either adjective describes Chop't.

	Much more 1	Slightly more 2	Neutral 3	Slightly more 4	Much more 5	
	1 (1)	2 (2)	3 (3)	4 (4)	5 (5)	
Bad	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Good
Unhealthy	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Healthy
Low Quality	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	High Quality
Expensive	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Cheap
Inconvenient	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	Convenient

Q11 Based on your experience, please indicate the extent to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: "a Sweetgreen meal is worth the price I pay."

- ☐ Strongly Disagree (1)
- ☐ Somewhat disagree (2)
- ☐ Neither agree nor disagree (3)
- ☐ Somewhat agree (4)
- ☐ Strongly agree (5)

Q12 Based on your experience please indicate the extent to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: "The portion size at Sweetgreen is appropriate for the price charged."

- ☐ Strongly Disagree (1)

- ☐ Somewhat Disagree (2)
- ☐ Neither agree nor Disagree (3)
- ☐ Somewhat Agree (4)
- ☐ Strongly Agree (5)

Q13 How has your Sweetgreen visit frequency changed over the past year?

- ☐ Increased (1)
- ☐ Decreased (2)
- ☐ This is my first year visiting Sweetgreen (3)
- ☐ Same as previous year (4)
- ☐ I have never eaten at Sweetgreen. (5)

Q14 If sweetgreen were to change the aspects below, would you be more or less likely to eat there?

	Much less likely (1)	Somewhat less likely (2)	No change (3)	Somewhat more likely (4)	Much more likely (5)
Increase in Portion Size (1)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Cheaper Meal (2)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Increased Diversity of Options (3)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Stronger Loyalty Program (4)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Q15 What would make Sweetgreen feel more “worth it”? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen.

	No more worth it (1)	A little more worth it (2)	Moderately more worth it (3)	Much more worth it (4)

Lower Prices (1)	☐	☐	☐	☐
More Discounts (2)	☐	☐	☐	☐
Bigger Portions (3)	☐	☐	☐	☐
Better Loyalty Program (4)	☐	☐	☐	☐
More Menu Variety (5)	☐	☐	☐	☐
Faster Pickup (6)	☐	☐	☐	☐
More Locations (7)	☐	☐	☐	☐

Q16 When was the last time you ordered from Cava?

- ☐ Within the last 7 days (1)
- ☐ Within the last 2 weeks (2)
- ☐ Within the last month (3)
- ☐ Within the last 6 months (4)
- ☐ Within the last year (5)
- ☐ Never (6)

Q17 When was the last time you ordered from Chop't?

- ☐ Within the last 7 days (1)
- ☐ Within the last 2 weeks (2)
- ☐ Within the last month (3)
- ☐ Within the last 6 months (4)
- ☐ Within the last year (5)
- ☐ Never (6)

Q18 When was the last time you ordered from Chipotle?

- ☐ Within the last 7 days (1)
- ☐ Within the last 2 weeks (2)
- ☐ Within the last month (3)
- ☐ Within the last 6 months (4)
- ☐ Within the last year (5)
- ☐ Never (6)

Q19 When was the last time you ordered from Honeygrow?

- ☐ Within the last 7 days (1)
- ☐ Within the last 2 weeks (2)
- ☐ Within the last month (3)
- ☐ Within the last 6 months (4)
- ☐ Within the last year (5)
- ☐ Never (6)

Q20 Which of the following do you visit most often instead of Sweetgreen

- ☐ Cava (1)
- ☐ Chopt (2)
- ☐ Chipotle (3)
- ☐ Honeygrow (4)
- ☐ Other (5)

Q21 Why this alternative over sweetgreen? One sentence to explain is enough.

Q22 Compared to each brand listed below, how expensive do you consider Sweetgreen?

	Much less expensive (1)	A little less expensive (2)	About the same price (3)	A little more expensive (4)	Much more expensive (5)
Cava (1)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Chopt (2)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Chipotle (3)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
Honeygrow (4)	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

End of Block: Questions Part 1

Start of Block: Sweetgreen Marketing and App Usage

Q23 In the past 6 months did you see any advertisements for Sweetgreen?

- ☐ Yes (1)
- ☐ No (2)
- ☐ Maybe (3)
- ☐ Unsure (4)

Q24 After seeing Sweetgreen's recent advertisements, how has your likelihood of visiting Sweetgreen changed?"

- ☐ Much less likely (1)
- ☐ Somewhat less likely (2)
- ☐ No change (3)
- ☐ Somewhat more likely (4)
- ☐ Much more likely (5)

☐ I have not seen any advertisements (6)

Q25 Have you used the Sweetgreen app in the last 6 months?

☐ Yes (1)

☐ No (2)

☐ Unsure (3)

Q25b If you use the app, tell us why you use it. If you do not use the app, tell us why you don't use it.

Q26 Are you a member of the sweetgreen loyalty program?

☐ Yes (1)

☐ No (2)

☐ Unsure (3)

Q27 If sweetgreen could change one thing, what should it be?

End of Block: Sweetgreen Marketing and App Usage

Start of Block: Final

Q28 Are you currently a college student?

- ☐ Yes (1)
- ☐ No (2)

Q29 What age are you?

End of Block: Final

Appendix C: SPSS Output

The following figures present the SPSS output used to support the quantitative findings discussed in the main report. Results are organized by research question. Figures are labeled in the order in which they are referenced in the text.

Figure C1: Spearman Correlation — Perceived Value and Visit Frequency

Survey Question (Q11): "A Sweetgreen meal is worth the price I pay." (Strongly disagree = 1 to Strongly agree = 5)

Survey Question (Q7): When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen? (lower values = more frequent visits)

Response Scale (Q11): Strongly disagree (1) to Strongly agree (5); lower Q7 values indicate more frequent visits.

			When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?	Based on your experience, please indicate the extent to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: "a Sweetgreen meal is worth the price I pay."
Kendall's tau_b	When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	-.323**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	<.001
		N	92	92
	Based on your experience, please indicate the extent to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: "a Sweetgreen meal is worth the price I pay."	Correlation Coefficient	-.323**	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	<.001	.
		N	92	92
Spearman's rho	When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	-.403**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	<.001
		N	92	92
	Based on your experience, please indicate the extent to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: "a Sweetgreen meal is worth the price I pay."	Correlation Coefficient	-.403**	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	<.001	.
		N	92	92

Result: A Spearman correlation analysis revealed a significant negative relationship between perceived value and visit frequency ($p = -0.403$, $p < .001$). Customers who believe Sweetgreen is worth the price tend to visit more frequently. The strength of this relationship is moderate to strong, suggesting that perceived value is an important driver of customer behavior.

Figure C2: Spearman Correlation — Perceived Portion Fairness and Visit Frequency

Survey Question (Q12): Based on your experience, please indicate the extent to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: "The portion size at Sweetgreen is appropriate for the price charged."

Survey Question (Q7): When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?

			When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?	please indicate the extent to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: "The portion size at Sweetgreen is appropriate for the price charged."
Kendall's tau_b	When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	-.382**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	<.001
		N	92	92
	Based on your experience please indicate the extent to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: "The portion size at Sweetgreen is appropriate for the price charged."	Correlation Coefficient	-.382**	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	<.001	.
		N	92	92
Spearman's rho	When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	-.459**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	<.001
		N	92	92
	Based on your experience please indicate the extent to which you agree or disagree with the following statement: "The portion size at Sweetgreen is appropriate for the price charged."	Correlation Coefficient	-.459**	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	<.001	.
		N	92	92

Result: A Spearman correlation analysis revealed a significant negative relationship between perceived portion fairness and visit frequency ($p = -0.459$, $p < .001$). Customers who believe Sweetgreen's portion sizes are appropriate for the price tend to visit more frequently. The strength of this relationship suggests that portion size is a key driver of customer behavior — even more so than price alone.

Figure C3: Spearman Correlation — Brand Perceptions (Healthiness, Quality, Expensiveness) and Visit Frequency

Survey Question (Q8): *For each pair of adjectives below, select the point between them that reflects the extent to which you believe either adjective describes Sweetgreen. (Unhealthy–Healthy; Expensive–Cheap; Low Quality–High Quality)*

Survey Question (Q7): *When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?*

H₀: Visit frequency (Q7) is not significantly associated with brand perceptions of healthiness, quality, and expensiveness (Q8).

H_a: Visit frequency (Q7) is significantly associated with brand perceptions of healthiness, quality, and expensiveness (Q8).

		Low Quality:High Quality				
Spearman's rho	When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	-.298**	.045	-.432**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	.009	.699	<.001
		N	77	75	75	75
	For each pair of adjectives below, select the point between them that reflects the extent to which you believe either adjective describes Sweetgreen. - Unhealthy:Healthy	Correlation Coefficient	-.298**	1.000	-.163	.385**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.009	.	.162	<.001
		N	75	75	75	75
	For each pair of adjectives below, select the point between them that reflects the extent to which you believe either adjective describes Sweetgreen. - Expensive:Cheap	Correlation Coefficient	.045	-.163	1.000	-.157
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.699	.162	.	.180
		N	75	75	75	75
	For each pair of adjectives below, select the point between them that reflects the extent to which you believe either adjective describes Sweetgreen. - Low Quality:High Quality	Correlation Coefficient	-.432**	.385**	-.157	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	<.001	<.001	.180	.
		N	75	75	75	75

** . Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).

Result: Perceived quality is the strongest driver of visit frequency ($\rho = -0.432$, $p < .001$) — customers who view Sweetgreen as higher quality visit more often. Perceptions of healthiness also have a significant though more moderate relationship with visit behavior ($\rho = -0.298$, $p = .009$). In contrast, perceptions of expensiveness are not significantly related to visit frequency ($\rho = 0.045$, $p = .699$), indicating that simply viewing Sweetgreen as expensive or cheap does not meaningfully influence visit behavior. Overall, customer behavior is driven more by perceived quality and health benefits than by price level alone.

Figure C4: Spearman Correlation — Competitor Visit Frequency and Sweetgreen Visit Frequency

Survey Questions (Q16–Q19): *When was the last time you ordered from Cava / Chopt / Chipotle / Honeygrow?*

Survey Question (Q7): *When was the last time you ate at Sweetgreen?*

H_0 : There is no significant association between visit frequency to competitors (Cava, Chipotle, Chopt, Honeygrow) and Sweetgreen visit frequency.

H_a : More frequent visits to competitors are associated with lower Sweetgreen visit frequency.

Correlations			When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?	When was the last time you ordered from Chipotle?	When was the last time you ordered from Chopt?	When was the last time you ordered from Honeygrow?	When was the last time you ordered from Cava?
Spearman's rho	When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	.143	.365**	-.024	.174
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	.218	.001	.835	.132
		N	77	76	76	76	76
	When was the last time you ordered from Chipotle?	Correlation Coefficient	.143	1.000	-.012	.203	-.038
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.218	.	.921	.078	.749
		N	76	76	76	76	75
	When was the last time you ordered from Chopt?	Correlation Coefficient	.365**	-.012	1.000	-.167	.057
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.001	.921	.	.150	.628
		N	76	76	76	76	75
	When was the last time you ordered from Honeygrow?	Correlation Coefficient	-.024	.203	-.167	1.000	.010
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.835	.078	.150	.	.931
		N	76	76	76	76	75
	When was the last time you ordered from Cava?	Correlation Coefficient	.174	-.038	.057	.010	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.132	.749	.628	.931	.
		N	76	75	75	75	76

** . Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).

Result: Spearman correlation analysis revealed a significant positive relationship between visit frequency to Chopt and Sweetgreen ($\rho = 0.365$, $p = .001$). Because lower values indicate more frequent visits, this suggests that customers who visit Chopt more frequently also tend to visit Sweetgreen more frequently, indicating overlapping customer behavior rather than a substitution effect between the two brands. Relationships with Chipotle ($\rho = 0.143$, $p = .218$), Cava ($\rho = 0.174$, $p = .132$), and Honeygrow ($\rho = -0.024$, $p = .835$) were not statistically significant, indicating that these brands do not show a strong relationship with Sweetgreen visit frequency.

Figure C5: Spearman Correlation — Perceived Price Relative to Competitors and Visit Frequency

Survey Question (Q22): *Compared to each brand listed below, how expensive do you consider Sweetgreen? (Compared to Cava / Chipotle / Honeygrow / Chopt)*

Survey Question (Q7): *When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?*

H_0 : There is no significant association between perceived price of Sweetgreen relative to competitors (Q22) and visit frequency (Q7).

H_a : Customers who perceive Sweetgreen as more expensive relative to competitors visit less frequently.

		Correlations					
		When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?	Compared to each brand listed below how expensive do you consider Sweetgreen? - Cava	Compared to each brand listed below how expensive do you consider Sweetgreen? - Chipotle	Compared to each brand listed below how expensive do you consider Sweetgreen? - Honeygrow	Compared to each brand listed below how expensive do you consider Sweetgreen? - Chopt	
Spearman's rho	When was the last time you ate Sweetgreen?	Correlation Coefficient	1.000	.208	.215	.038	.269*
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.	.071	.062	.755	.022
		N	77	76	76	71	72
	Compared to each brand listed below how expensive do you consider Sweetgreen? - Cava	Correlation Coefficient	.208	1.000	.451**	.401**	.486**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.071	.	<.001	<.001	<.001
		N	76	76	76	71	72
	Compared to each brand listed below how expensive do you consider Sweetgreen? - Chipotle	Correlation Coefficient	.215	.451**	1.000	.309**	.433**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.062	<.001	.	.009	<.001
		N	76	76	76	71	72
	Compared to each brand listed below how expensive do you consider Sweetgreen? - Honeygrow	Correlation Coefficient	.038	.401**	.309**	1.000	.482**
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.755	<.001	.009	.	<.001
		N	71	71	71	71	70
	Compared to each brand listed below how expensive do you consider Sweetgreen? - Chopt	Correlation Coefficient	.269*	.486**	.433**	.482**	1.000
		Sig. (2-tailed)	.022	<.001	<.001	<.001	.
		N	72	72	72	70	72

*. Correlation is significant at the 0.05 level (2-tailed).

**. Correlation is significant at the 0.01 level (2-tailed).

Result: The results show that perceived expensiveness relative to Chopt is the only comparison that has a significant relationship with visit behavior ($p = 0.269$, $p = .022$). Given that higher values of Q7 indicate less frequent visits, this positive relationship suggests that customers who perceive Sweetgreen as more expensive than Chopt tend to visit less often. In contrast, perceived price differences relative to Cava ($p = 0.208$, $p = .071$), Chipotle ($p = 0.215$, $p = .062$), and Honeygrow ($p = 0.038$, $p = .755$) are not statistically significant, indicating that relative price perceptions across these brands do not show a strong relationship with visit frequency. Overall, these findings suggest that price sensitivity is most relevant in direct comparison to Chopt, highlighting its closer competitive positioning relative to Sweetgreen.

Figure C6: Frequencies — Most Frequent Competitor Visited Instead of Sweetgreen

Survey Question (Q20): Which of the following do you visit most often instead of Sweetgreen?

► **Frequencies**

Statistics

Which of the following do you visit most often instead of Sweetgreen

N	Valid	76
	Missing	2
Median		3.00

Which of the following do you visit most often instead of Sweetgreen

		Frequency	Percent	Valid Percent	Cumulative Percent
Valid	Cava	25	32.1	32.9	32.9
	Chipotle	46	59.0	60.5	93.4
	Honeygrow	1	1.3	1.3	94.7
	Other	4	5.1	5.3	100.0
	Total	76	97.4	100.0	
Missing	System	2	2.6		
Total		78	100.0		

Result: Descriptive analysis of competitor preference shows that Chipotle is the most frequently visited alternative to Sweetgreen, accounting for 60.5% of responses (n = 46). Cava follows at 32.9% (n = 25), while Honeygrow (1.3%) and other restaurants (5.3%) are minimally represented. Although Chipotle captures the largest share of visits, prior correlation analysis indicates that Chopt is more directly associated with reduced Sweetgreen visits, suggesting it functions as a closer substitute competitor.

Figure C7: Means — Advertisement Exposure and Likelihood of Visiting

Survey Question (Q23): *In the past 6 months, did you see any advertisements for Sweetgreen?*

Survey Question (Q24): *After seeing Sweetgreen's recent advertisements, how has your likelihood of visiting Sweetgreen changed?*

➔ Means

Case Processing Summary

	Included		Cases Excluded		Total	
	N	Percent	N	Percent	N	Percent
After seeing Sweetgreen's recent advertisements, how has your likelihood of visiting Sweetgreen changed?" * Ads_group	78	100.0%	0	0.0%	78	100.0%

Report

After seeing Sweetgreen's recent advertisements, how has your likelihood of visiting Sweetgreen changed?"

Ads_group	Mean	N	Median	Std. Deviation
.00	3.07	30	3.00	.254
1.00	3.25	48	3.00	.601
Total	3.18	78	3.00	.503

Result: Median likelihood of visiting was identical for both groups (Median = 3), indicating no change in customer intent regardless of advertisement exposure. While the mean likelihood was marginally higher among those who had seen advertisements (M = 3.25 vs. M = 3.07), this difference is minimal and does not reflect a meaningful behavioral shift. Advertisement exposure does not meaningfully change customer behavior.

Figure C8: Descriptive Statistics — Factors That Would Make Sweetgreen Feel More "Worth It"

Survey Question (Q15): *What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important. (Lower mean = ranked more important)*

Descriptive Statistics

	N	Minimum	Maximum	Mean	Std. Deviation
What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - Lower Prices	73	1	4	3.38	.757
What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - Bigger Portions	73	1	4	2.75	.878
What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - More Discounts	72	1	4	3.04	.795
What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - More Menu Variety	71	1	4	2.20	.950

What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - Better Loyalty Program	73	1	4	2.18	1.045
What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - Faster Pickup	73	1	4	2.01	1.034
What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - More Locations	73	1	4	2.26	1.054
Valid N (listwise)	70				

Result: Lower prices are rated as the most important driver of perceived value ($M = 3.38$), followed by more discounts ($M = 3.04$) and bigger portions ($M = 2.75$). Other factors ranked notably lower, including more locations ($M = 2.26$), menu variety ($M = 2.20$), a better loyalty program ($M = 2.18$), and faster pickup ($M = 2.01$).

Figure C9: Means by Student Status — Factors That Would Make Sweetgreen Feel More "Worth It"

Survey Question (Q15): *What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? (Same ranking question as Figure C8, split by Survey Question (Q28): Are you currently a college student?*

Type in Search field to find help topics, dialogs, and case studies containing

		Report						
		What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - Lower Prices	What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - Bigger Portions	What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - More Discounts	What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - More Menu Variety	What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - Better Loyalty Program	What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - More Locations	What would make Sweetgreen feel more "worth it"? Rank these options from most to least important in what would change your mind about purchasing Sweetgreen. - Faster Pickup
Yes	Mean	3.40	2.84	3.07	2.20	2.16	2.28	2.04
	N	57	57	57	55	57	57	57
	Median	4.00	3.00	3.00	2.00	2.00	2.00	2.00
	Std. Deviation	.776	.882	.753	.911	1.014	1.085	1.085
No	Mean	3.31	2.44	2.93	2.19	2.25	2.19	1.94
	N	16	16	15	16	16	16	16
	Median	3.00	2.50	3.00	2.00	2.00	2.00	2.00
	Std. Deviation	.704	.814	.961	1.109	1.183	1.047	.854
Total	Mean	3.38	2.75	3.04	2.20	2.18	2.26	2.01
	N	73	73	72	71	73	73	73
	Median	4.00	3.00	3.00	2.00	2.00	2.00	2.00
	Std. Deviation	.757	.878	.795	.950	1.045	1.054	1.034

Result: Both college and non-college respondents rank lower prices highest (college: $M = 3.40$; non-college: $M = 3.31$), followed by more discounts (college: $M = 3.07$; non-college: $M = 2.93$). The largest difference between groups is for larger portions, which were rated meaningfully higher by college respondents ($M = 2.84$) than by non-college respondents ($M = 2.44$). All remaining factors are rated similarly across groups, indicating broad alignment in priorities regardless of student status.